CHAPTER 10 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Colfax Massacre

The deadliest single act of violence in Reconstruction — and the court case that used it to gut the federal protection of rights. 1873.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The deadliest single act of violence in Reconstruction — and the court case that used it to gut the federal protection of rights. 1873.

Can a single terrible event, and the court case that follows it, change the course of a nation's history?

A Disputed Election Turns Deadly

EASTER 1873 · LOUISIANA

After a disputed Louisiana election, Black Republicans and a Black militia occupied the courthouse in Colfax to defend the result. On Easter Sunday, 1873, a large armed white mob attacked them.

The Black defenders were overwhelmed. In the massacre that followed, dozens — by some counts over a hundred — Black men were killed, many after they had surrendered. It was the bloodiest single day of Reconstruction.

“Worse Than Slavery”

THOMAS NAST, 1874

Nast drew the terror unleashed on Black families by the White League and the Klan, under a banner reading “Worse than Slavery.” Colfax was the most horrific example of this violence.

“The Union As It Was — The Lost Cause, Worse Than Slavery” — wood engraving by Thomas Nast, Harper's Weekly, 1874, public domain (Library of Congress).

United States v. Cruikshank

THE COURTROOM

The federal government prosecuted some of the attackers under the Enforcement Acts. But in United States v. Cruikshank (1876), the Supreme Court threw out the convictions.

The Court ruled that the Fourteenth Amendment protected citizens only against state governments — not against violence by private individuals. Protecting people from a mob, the Court said, was the job of the states — the very states now falling under white Democratic control.

Redemption, 1869–77 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

A Door Slammed Shut

WHY IT MATTERS

The significance of Cruikshank is hard to overstate. It crippled the federal government's power to protect Black citizens from racial terror, exactly when that protection was most needed.

After Colfax and Cruikshank, those who used violence to overthrow Black political power had far less to fear from Washington. The ruling helped open the door to the triumph of “Redemption” and, eventually, Jim Crow.

Weigh the Evidence

YOUR TURN

You'll examine what happened at Colfax and in its aftermath, and practice using evidence and judging historical significance.